CONTENT WRITING · PUBLISHED ESSAY, MAKOOLA

I’m Not Grateful to Be Here. I Worked for This.

Motolani Deborah Akinyemi

> *We’re told to smile, shrink, and show gratitude for the bare minimum – but what happens when you’ve outgrown humility as a survival tactic? This is what it means to be exceptional, exhausted, and done apologizing for it.*

The Thank-You That Nearly Choked Me

I remember the moment clearly. The air had that quiet tension after I finished presenting – the kind that lingers when people don’t know what to say because you said it all. Heads nodded. One person clapped, a little too latex, before every other person joined with a handful, even standing. Then a senior exec leaned in, smiled, and said, "That was powerful. You should be grateful for opportunities like this."

Grateful?

For telling the truth with clarity? For carrying the weight of the unspoken in a room not built for me? For being prepared, practiced, and damn good?

I smiled – because that’s what we’re taught to do. Especially when you’re the only Black woman in the room. Especially when you’ve spent your whole life working twice as hard to be seen as half as capable. But my stomach twisted.

I realized in that moment that I had confused the language of humility with the habits of erasure. That I had been taught to say thank you, even when what I wanted to say was: I earned this. Every inch of it.

The Unwritten Rules in White-Dominated Spaces

Let’s be honest. There’s a script we’re handed when we enter rooms we weren’t "expected" to thrive in:

- Speak well, but not too confidently.

- Be brilliant, but never intimidating.

- Be humble, but still sparkle enough to represent "diversity."

There’s an entire choreography to how we’re supposed to take up space. A balancing act that punishes pride and rewards palatability. And when you’re taught to constantly make yourself

small, you start to believe that visibility itself is a gift – even when it was your labor, your genius, your grind that opened the door.

Former First Lady Michelle Obama once said, "I have been at every powerful table you can think of. They are not that smart." It wasn't an insult. It was a necessary unveiling – a moment of truth for those of us who internalize the idea that we're lucky to be in the room, instead of knowing we earned it.

Over-Performance As a Survival Skill

Being raised to over-perform is something many of us inherit without question. Especially when you grow up knowing that your excellence is expected to "prove them wrong."

In school, in jobs, in business pitches – there's a pressure to be flawless. To be the exception. To be so good they can't deny you, but still quiet enough that they won't fear you.

It looks like:

- Double-checking every word in an email so you don't sound "aggressive"

- Taking on extra work without credit, just to seem "dedicated."

- Apologizing before offering a bold idea

We carry this weight into adulthood like armor, but no one tells you the armor eventually becomes heavy. That it rusts. That it closes in.

In her 2020 MacTaggart Lecture, actress and writer Michaela Coel spoke about rejecting industry standards that made her feel invisible: "I didn't feel I belonged in the rooms I was in, not because of me, but because they weren't built for me."

Her decision to walk away from a million-dollar Netflix deal in order to retain rights to her work led to the creation of I May Destroy You, a show that redefined ownership and authorship in modern TV.

Impostor Syndrome? Or Systemic Gaslighting?

Let me say something plainly: impostor syndrome didn't come out of nowhere.

Many of us feel like impostors not because we lack skill, but because the systems we navigate are built to make us doubt our belonging. If every room you enter feels surprised by your brilliance, of course you start to internalize that you don't quite fit.

But here's the truth: I don't feel like an impostor anymore. Because I know exactly what I bring. I've worked, studied, rebuilt myself after failure, held entire teams on my back, coached others

through their moments of fear, and still showed up with clarity and care.

And yet, there are moments. Like when someone tells me, "Wow, you're so articulate," as if it's a shock. Or when praise feels like a warning wrapped in a compliment: Be grateful you're here.

No. I'm not grateful. I'm qualified.

Tennis legend, Serena Williams has spoken about this double standard throughout her career. In a candid 2019 essay for Harper's Bazaar, she reflected on the backlash she faced after the 2018 U.S. Open final.

"I've been called angry. It's been said that I've had outbursts. I've been penalized," she wrote. "And yet my passion and drive have been mistaken for something else entirely."

Her decision to speak openly was not just personal – it was political, a refusal to be silent in the face of deeply racialized expectations. (Read the full essay here)

She wrote about being told to "stay quiet" after demanding fairness on the court. Her words hit deep: "We are not allowed to have emotions, we are not allowed to be passionate. We are told to sit down and be quiet, which frankly is just not something I'm OK with."

Humility Isn't the Same As Shrinking

Don't get me wrong. Humility is a virtue – when it's chosen.

But what we often perform isn't humility. It's preemptive deference. A practiced self-minimizing to prevent being labeled arrogant or difficult. We're told to stay humble so others can stay comfortable.

I've started catching myself every time I'm tempted to downplay my skills.

- I stop apologizing for knowing what I know.

- I stop performing smallness to soothe others.

- I stop pretending my presence is a gift to me when it's actually a gift to the room.

In her viral speech at Essence Fest, author and activist Brittany Packnett Cunningham said: "Confidence is not cocky. Confidence is clarity. Confidence is knowing your worth, even when the world tries to write you out of the story."

Reclaiming Confidence as a Cultural Reset

We need a cultural reset on what confidence looks like in our bodies, in our tongues, in our skin.

I want more of us to:

- Speak with clarity without checking for permission

- Enter rooms like we belong because we do

- Let our resumes and results speak, and let our presence speak louder

This isn’t about arrogance. It’s about accuracy. It’s about walking with the full weight of your knowing and not shrinking it to fit someone else's comfort zone.

What Gratitude Should Really Look Like

True gratitude? It’s internal.

I’m grateful to my mentors, my ancestors, my younger self who kept going when it was lonely. I’m grateful to the nights I cried through deadlines, the communities who reminded me I wasn’t crazy for wanting more.

But I will not perform gratitude for being allowed into rooms I kicked open.

Because I worked for this. And I’m still working.

Final Word: Pride Is Not a Sin. It’s a Survival Strategy.

If you’re reading this and feeling it in your chest – you’re not alone. If you’re tired of smiling through insult, of being grateful for scraps while carrying gold in your spirit, hear me:

You don’t have to earn your existence.

You don’t have to apologize for being excellent.

You don’t have to shrink to be safe.

We are here. And we are not grateful to be here.

We worked for this.

Why This Story Lives Here

Makolaa exists to hold space for stories like this – stories that speak truth to exhaustion, to excellence, to inheritance. We are not just a platform. We are a home for Black creatives, entrepreneurs, and thinkers who deserve more than visibility. We deserve each other.

Author: Motolani Akinyemi